SPACE FACTS

8 things to know about our corner of the universe

1. ## The Sun is a star

It is an ordinary yellow-dwarf star about 4.6 billion years old. About 1.3 million Earths would fit inside it.

2. ## Light takes time

Sunlight takes about 8 minutes 20 seconds to reach Earth. When you look at the Sun's glow, you see the past.

3. ## Jupiter is the giant

Jupiter has more mass than all the other planets combined. Its Great Red Spot is a storm wider than Earth.

4. ## Venus is hottest

Venus is not closest to the Sun, but its thick carbon-dioxide air traps heat: about 465 C at the surface.

5. ## The Moon drifts away

Laser mirrors left by Apollo astronauts show the Moon moves about 3.8 cm farther from Earth each year.

6. ## A day on Venus

Venus spins so slowly that one day there (243 Earth days) is longer than its year (225 Earth days).

7. ## Saturn's rings are thin

The ring system reaches up to 282,000 km from the planet, yet the main rings are typically only about 10 metres thick. They are mostly chunks of water ice.

8. ## Our galaxy

The Milky Way holds roughly 100 to 400 billion stars. The Sun takes about 230 million years to orbit its centre.

WOW NUMBER

If the Sun were a 1 m beach ball, Earth would be a peppercorn about 107 m away - and the nearest other star would be about 29,000 km away.